

Video Transcripts

Module 8: Agentic AI in Business Functions II – Disruptive innovations

Video 1: From Firm to Autonomous Enterprise

Agentic AI represents a significant shift beyond generative AI by moving from assisting with tasks such as content creation and analysis to autonomously managing complex, multi-step workflows. While generative AI enhances existing processes, agentic AI enables organisations to rethink how work is done altogether. It introduces systems capable of making decisions and executing actions independently, thereby transforming traditional operational structures and the role humans play within them.

Historically, organisations have relied on human-driven workflows, where individuals gather information, coordinate across departments, and carry out tasks with the support of technology. Agentic AI changes this dynamic by placing automated intelligence at the centre of operations. Instead of humans driving every process, AI agents take on the responsibility of observing conditions, making decisions, and acting in real time across functions such as procurement, finance, marketing, and human resources.

In an autonomous enterprise, workflows no longer depend on continuous human involvement. AI agents operate continuously, ensuring processes do not pause due to availability constraints or delays in communication. Decisions are made rapidly based on real-time data rather than prolonged discussions, enabling a faster and more adaptive organisational response. This results in a more fluid and efficient way of operating, where the organisation can respond dynamically to changing conditions.

A practical illustration of this model can be seen in a smart urban power grid. In such a system, AI agents monitor energy usage across the city, automatically adjust pricing, manage energy distribution, and coordinate maintenance activities such as dispatching drones when issues are detected. Humans define the overarching goals and safety parameters, but the agents manage the complexity of operations independently and continuously.

As a result, the role of humans evolves from direct task execution to oversight and strategic direction. Leaders focus on setting objectives, defining ethical boundaries, and intervening when necessary. This transition does not remove the importance of human input but instead elevates it, emphasising judgement, governance, and long-term vision. Organisations that successfully adopt this approach, while maintaining clear oversight and alignment with core values, will be best positioned to harness the full potential of agentic AI.

Video 2: AI-Driven Business Models

AI-driven business models represent a significant shift in how organisations create and deliver value. Instead of treating AI as a support tool, these models place intelligent systems at the centre of operations. Decision-making, service delivery, and customer interactions are increasingly handled by autonomous agents, allowing businesses to move away from manual, human-driven workflows towards more automated and efficient processes.

Traditionally, organisations have relied on people to execute tasks, with technology playing a secondary role. In contrast, AI-driven models embed intelligence directly into core operations. For example, in advanced manufacturing environments, AI systems can continuously monitor data, predict issues, and autonomously adjust production in real time. This shifts the model from reactive human intervention to proactive, self-optimising operations that maintain high levels of quality and efficiency.

This approach also enables organisations to scale in ways that were previously difficult or impossible. AI-powered systems can process large volumes of data instantly, allowing services such as automated credit approval or dynamic logistics management to operate with speed and precision. Businesses can respond to changing conditions immediately, whether that involves approving transactions or rerouting supply chains, improving both resilience and customer experience.

However, adopting an AI-driven model requires more than deploying technology. Organisations must redesign processes and establish strong governance frameworks. As AI takes over execution, human roles evolve towards strategy, oversight, and ethical decision-making. Ultimately, businesses that successfully integrate AI at their core will gain a sustainable competitive advantage by combining automation with thoughtful human guidance.

Video 3: Disintermediation via Agents

Agentic AI is driving a major shift in how organisations operate by enabling the removal of intermediaries and replacing them with direct execution models. While disintermediation has existed since the rise of the internet—where digital platforms connected buyers and sellers more directly—agentic AI extends this concept by eliminating the need for coordination itself. Instead of simply facilitating interactions, intelligent agents can independently make decisions and carry out transactions, reducing reliance on human involvement at each stage.

In conventional business structures, intermediaries such as brokers, coordinators, and managers exist to manage complexity. They gather and assess information, coordinate between stakeholders, and ensure tasks progress in the correct sequence. These roles are necessary because humans have limits in processing large volumes of data, working across multiple systems simultaneously, and maintaining continuous oversight. Agentic AI addresses these constraints by operating continuously, processing information in real time, and acting across interconnected systems without interruption.

Procurement provides a clear example of this transformation. Traditionally, procurement managers act as a bridge between organisations and suppliers, collecting quotes, negotiating terms, and coordinating approvals. With agentic AI, these activities can be executed autonomously. Intelligent

systems can monitor supply requirements, interact with approved vendors, evaluate responses against predefined criteria, and complete purchasing decisions independently. This shifts the human role away from routine coordination towards strategic planning, supplier relationship management, and oversight of system behaviour.

Enterprise platforms such as Workday and Coupa are increasingly embedding agentic capabilities to enable this level of automation, with early adopters reporting faster procurement cycles and reduced administrative workloads. Similar patterns are emerging in other industries. In financial services, advanced agents are taking on functions such as portfolio management, trade execution, and compliance monitoring. In customer service and legal operations, agents can manage entire workflows—from resolving customer issues to reviewing contracts—without the need for continuous human coordination.

Overall, disintermediation through agentic AI represents a structural evolution in how work is performed. By removing routine coordination roles and enabling direct execution, organisations can reduce costs, improve speed, and enhance operational efficiency. At the same time, human roles are elevated towards governance, accountability, and strategic direction. Organisations that manage this transition carefully, ensuring clear boundaries and responsible oversight, will be best positioned to fully realise the benefits of agentic AI.

Video 4: Autonomous Customer Journeys

Agentic AI is transforming customer engagement through the autonomous customer journey, where intelligent agents manage the entire experience from discovery to post-purchase. Instead of relying on human-led sales interactions, businesses can now deliver seamless, personalised journeys that operate continuously and proactively.

Phase 1: Discovery & Intent

The journey begins with identifying intent through data signals such as search behaviour, content engagement, and past purchases. AI agents analyse these patterns to anticipate needs and present relevant recommendations. Rather than waiting for action, the system proactively engages, acting like a digital personal shopper.

Phase 2: Personalised Consideration

As customers evaluate options, AI adapts in real time. Tools such as augmented reality enable virtual product trials, while recommendation systems provide tailored comparisons and insights. The agent continuously refines suggestions based on user interactions, ensuring relevance and improving decision confidence.

Phase 3: Decision & Post-Purchase

At the decision stage, agents reduce friction by offering timely, personalised incentives based on purchase intent. After the transaction, the journey continues with automated follow-ups such as replenishment reminders and loyalty programme engagement, ensuring a smooth and continuous experience.

Overall, the autonomous customer journey allows organisations to deliver highly personalised experiences at scale. By automating the full lifecycle, businesses can improve speed, relevance, and customer satisfaction while gaining a strong competitive advantage.

Video 5: Personal AI Agents Representing Customers

Imagine a future where tasks such as comparing insurance plans, booking flights, or renewing subscriptions are handled entirely by a personal AI agent. These agents act as digital representatives, making decisions on behalf of individuals based on their preferences, budgets, and past behaviour. Instead of manually researching options, users rely on AI to search, compare, negotiate, and complete transactions.

This shift is already taking shape as more advanced agents emerge beyond early voice assistants. These systems can browse the web, evaluate options, and carry out tasks autonomously, reducing the need for direct user involvement. As their capabilities grow, personal AI agents increasingly take over routine decision-making processes that once required time and effort from individuals.

Unlike human consumers, AI agents do not respond to emotional advertising or visual persuasion. They evaluate choices using structured criteria such as price, quality, delivery timelines, and reliability. This leads to a more rational and data-driven marketplace, where decisions are based on measurable value rather than brand storytelling or impulse.

As a result, organisations must rethink their marketing strategies. Success depends on making products easily interpretable by AI through clear data, transparent pricing, and verified performance. In this emerging landscape, trust, consistency, and data quality become the key drivers of competitive advantage, as AI increasingly mediates the relationship between buyers and brands.

Video 6: Dynamic Marketplaces of Agents

Having explored how agents operate within organisations and on behalf of individual customers, the next development is the emergence of dynamic marketplaces of agents. In these environments, AI agents on both the buying and selling sides interact directly, reshaping how transactions are conducted. Instead of human-led exchanges, agents handle negotiation, pricing, and execution autonomously.

A dynamic marketplace of agents allows buyer and seller agents to communicate, evaluate options, and finalise agreements based on predefined rules. Rather than relying on procurement managers and sales representatives, these agents assess offers, negotiate terms, and complete contracts independently. This enables faster, more consistent decision-making while reducing the need for human intervention at every step.

One of the most established examples of this model can be seen in programmatic digital advertising. Here, buying and selling agents negotiate advertising space in real time through automated bidding systems. These transactions occur in milliseconds, with thousands of simultaneous negotiations

optimised for cost, relevance, and audience reach, all without human involvement in individual decisions.

This approach is also transforming supply chain management. Procurement agents can directly engage with supplier agents to compare inventory, pricing, and delivery timelines in real time. By autonomously selecting and contracting with the most suitable supplier, organisations can significantly reduce procurement cycle times, improving both efficiency and responsiveness across operations.

As these agent-driven marketplaces evolve, governance becomes essential. Organisations must clearly define negotiation boundaries, approval thresholds, and ethical guidelines to ensure agents act in alignment with strategy and regulations. Overall, dynamic marketplaces of agents represent a major shift in commerce, enabling faster, more efficient transactions while requiring careful oversight to ensure reliability and trust.

Video 7: Autonomous Product & Service Delivery

Delivering products and services has traditionally required significant human involvement across multiple stages, from order processing and fulfilment to service delivery and quality assurance. Agentic AI is now transforming this model by enabling autonomous, continuous delivery. As a result, humans are no longer required to manage each operational step and can instead focus on oversight and ongoing improvement.

Continuous delivery powered by agentic AI removes the limitations of human working hours and capacity. Intelligent agents monitor workflows, trigger fulfilment processes, coordinate logistics, and update customers in real time across different locations. When disruptions occur, such as delivery failures or service interruptions, agents can identify issues, evaluate possible solutions, and take corrective action without waiting for human input.

This model is already well established in digital services. For example, streaming platforms use AI to continuously optimise content delivery, personalise user experiences, and resolve performance issues automatically. If network conditions change, systems can adapt instantly to maintain quality, ensuring uninterrupted service without requiring manual intervention.

Agentic AI is also reshaping service execution in industries such as insurance and legal services. Claims processing systems can assess submissions, verify information, and initiate payouts for straightforward cases autonomously. Similarly, legal technology platforms use AI to review contracts, identify risks, and generate summaries, significantly reducing the need for manual effort and speeding up service delivery.

In high-speed consumer services, autonomous delivery models are enabling entirely new performance standards. AI-driven systems can monitor demand, optimise inventory, coordinate fulfilment, and manage last-mile delivery in real time. Overall, autonomous product and service delivery represents a fundamental shift, allowing organisations to operate at greater speed and scale while focusing human effort on design, quality, and strategic enhancement.

Video 8: Real-Time Business Reconfiguration

Traditionally, organisations have been structured around fixed models, with defined departments, set reporting lines, and resource allocations determined during periodic planning cycles. Adapting to change in such systems can take considerable time. Agentic AI introduces a new approach by enabling real-time business reconfiguration, where organisations can dynamically adjust their structure and priorities based on live data.

Real-time reconfiguration allows businesses to respond instantly to changing conditions. Instead of waiting for reviews or approvals, agentic systems continuously monitor external and internal signals, assess their impact, and make immediate adjustments. This transforms the organisation from a static structure into a fluid system that operates at the speed of data rather than the pace of traditional decision-making processes.

A strong example of this can be seen in fast-fashion models, where AI-driven systems track trends, customer preferences, and market signals in real time. When demand for a particular style increases, systems can automatically trigger production, adjust marketing focus, and prioritise logistics without requiring manual coordination. This enables companies to stay aligned with rapidly changing consumer demand.

A similar capability exists in sectors such as energy, where AI systems continuously monitor conditions and optimise operations. By analysing data such as demand fluctuations or equipment status, these systems can adjust distribution, manage loads, and prioritise maintenance activities in real time, ensuring efficiency and stability across complex operations.

Overall, real-time business reconfiguration represents a major shift in organisational design. By treating structure and resources as flexible rather than fixed, businesses can respond more effectively to uncertainty. With appropriate governance and oversight, this capability provides a significant competitive advantage in fast-moving and unpredictable markets.

Video 9: Autonomous Financial Management Systems

Financial management has traditionally required high levels of precision, speed, and constant oversight. Treasury teams track cash positions, investment managers monitor portfolios, and liquidity analysts assess funding needs across multiple accounts, currencies, and regions. These activities often run in parallel, relying heavily on human coordination and timely decision-making.

Agentic AI is transforming this landscape by enabling autonomous financial management. Intelligent agents continuously monitor an organisation's financial position in real time, identifying imbalances and acting immediately. For example, instead of manual reviews of cash balances, a treasury agent can detect surplus and deficit positions across accounts and automatically execute transfers to optimise cash utilisation and reduce idle funds.

Investment management is also being reshaped by agent-driven execution. Within predefined risk parameters set by humans, agents analyse market conditions, asset valuations, and portfolio exposures continuously. When adjustments are required, they autonomously rebalance portfolios and

execute trades, ensuring alignment with investment mandates without requiring constant human intervention.

Liquidity management benefits in a similar way. Agents forecast short-term cash needs using real-time data on payables and receivables, while monitoring available credit facilities. They can autonomously draw on or repay credit lines to maintain optimal liquidity levels. When more complex or high-risk situations arise, these systems escalate insights and recommendations to human decision-makers for final judgement.

Overall, autonomous financial management represents a major advancement in how organisations manage critical financial resources. By shifting routine execution to AI, organisations gain greater accuracy, responsiveness, and consistency. As this capability matures, finance professionals increasingly focus on strategy, risk definition, and oversight, ensuring that automated systems operate effectively and within defined boundaries.

Video 10: New Cost Structures: Near-Zero Coordination Cost

Financial management has long required precision, speed, and continuous oversight, with teams monitoring cash positions, managing investments, and tracking liquidity across multiple markets. Much of this effort has traditionally been spent not only on financial decisions themselves, but on coordinating activities—reviewing data, aligning stakeholders, and ensuring actions are executed in the correct sequence.

Agentic AI is now reducing these coordination costs by automating the underlying processes. When intelligent agents manage workflows, tasks such as approvals, reconciliations, and status updates happen autonomously and in real time. This removes the need for constant human intervention and significantly lowers the operational overhead associated with managing complex financial activities.

Rather than eliminating managerial roles, this shift changes their focus. Managers are no longer required to spend time on routine coordination and oversight. Instead, they can concentrate on higher-value responsibilities such as strategic planning, setting financial policies, and handling complex or exceptional situations. As a result, organisations become leaner and more efficient, with fewer delays caused by internal friction.

A strong example of this transformation is seen in organisations that have adopted decentralised operating models supported by AI. By using intelligent systems to coordinate activities across multiple units, they reduce reliance on centralised management structures. This enables faster decision-making and allows different parts of the business to remain aligned without the need for extensive reporting or manual intervention.

Overall, the reduction of coordination costs represents a major shift in business economics. By automating alignment and communication, organisations can operate with greater speed and efficiency. Those that redesign their structures to fully embrace this capability will gain a significant competitive advantage, as they are able to respond to change more quickly and with far less overhead.

Video 11: Strategic Risks of Agentic AI

Throughout this module, we have explored the potential of agentic AI, but alongside these opportunities come significant strategic risks that organisations must manage carefully. Deploying agents without fully understanding these risks can lead to serious consequences. Effective leadership requires anticipating where failures may occur and building safeguards into systems from the outset.

The first major risk is loss of control. As agents operate autonomously across complex workflows, the link between human oversight and execution can weaken. Agents make decisions at speeds and scale that humans cannot track in real time. If their operating parameters are unclear or incomplete, they may act in ways that do not align with organisational intent, and such misalignments may only become visible after damage has occurred.

The second risk is cascading errors, which are unique to interconnected agent systems. Because agents depend on each other's outputs, a single mistake can quickly propagate across multiple functions. For example, an incorrect demand signal could trigger excessive procurement and inventory decisions. Each agent may act logically within its own role, but the combined effect can result in large-scale unintended outcomes.

The third risk is over-automation. When organisations automate too extensively without maintaining human judgement at critical points, they risk becoming operationally fragile. If systems fail or encounter unexpected conditions, there may be insufficient human capability available to step in and manage the situation effectively.

To summarise, the risks of agentic AI—loss of control, cascading errors, and over-automation—are real but manageable. Organisations that proactively design governance frameworks, maintain oversight, and embed human judgement where necessary will be better positioned to harness the benefits of agentic AI while avoiding its potential pitfalls.

Video 12: Final Thoughts

We have reached the end of this module on Agentic AI in Business Functions — Disruptive Innovations. Agentic AI is not simply improving efficiency; it is fundamentally reshaping how organisations operate, compete, and create value. We explored the shift towards autonomous enterprises, where agents execute workflows and humans focus on supervision and strategy, alongside the growing impact of disintermediation, which removes traditional coordination roles across functions.

We also examined how autonomous customer journeys, personal AI agents, and dynamic marketplaces are transforming interactions between buyers and sellers. At the same time, AI-driven supply chains and financial systems are raising expectations for speed, precision, and continuous operation. These shifts enable organisations to scale without proportional increases in workforce, redefining productivity and competitive advantage.

However, these opportunities come with clear strategic risks, including loss of control, cascading errors, and over-automation. To navigate this landscape successfully, organisations must prioritise governance, ethical oversight, and resilience. Those that embrace agentic AI thoughtfully will not only adapt but will play a defining role in shaping the future of business.